

Q&A

Your Questions, Our Answers

Questionable licenses and truant uninstallers—all dealt with right here!

Securing The Key

Q I believe Windows XP activation can be backed up to a floppy for later retrieval in case of a reinstall. How is this done?

Sanjay Ghosal

A Create an Activation Status Floppy Diskette: navigate to the %systemroot%\system32 folder. Copy the wpa.dbl and wpa.bak files to the floppy. Reinstall XP. After the install is complete and the XP Out Of Box Experience (OOBE) window appears—where you'd normally activate the product—decline to activate and let the installation complete. Restart and use [F8] to bring up the Advanced Boot Options menu.

Select Minimal Safe Mode here. Navigate to the %systemroot%\system32 folder. Rename the existing wpa.dbl and wpa.bak files. Using the floppy diskette, copy the previously backed-up wpa.dbl and wpa.bak to the %systemroot%\system32 folder. Reboot; XP should be activated.

Cracking The Code

Q How do I create a password reset disk for XP, and how do I use it if I lose my password?

Pramod Negi

A There's something called the Forgotten Password Wizard, which allows you to create a password reset disk that can be used to recover password and personalised computer settings if the password is forgotten. The steps to perform the task differ for domain and work-group scenarios.

If your computer is on a domain, you can create the Domain Password Reset Disk as follows. Press [Ctrl] + [Alt] + [Delete] to open the Windows Security dialog box. Click Change Password. Click Backup to open the Forgotten Password Wizard. Click Next, then follow the on-screen instructions.

If your computer is not part of a domain, you can create a Non-Domain Password Reset Disk; the procedure here varies depending on whether you have an administrator account or a limited account.

If you have an administrator account, create an Administrator Password Reset Disk: open User Accounts in the Control Panel. Select the Administrator. Click Prevent A Forgotten Password under Related Tasks. Follow the instructions in the Forgotten Password Wizard. For a Limited Account Password Reset Disk, do the same, but by

selecting the Limited User Account instead of Administrator.

Here's how to use the Password Reset Disk to log on to a computer: boot through the disk you created. Click the username whose password is on the recovery disk. Press [Enter] or the Right Arrow. This causes the "Did You Forget Your Password?" message to appear. You can click the "?" button to see your password hint. If you have forgotten this as well, you can use your Password Reset Disk to reset your password. This will start the Password Reset Wizard. Follow the instructions and you will be able to set a new password. The Password Reset Disk is also automatically updated with the new password information, so you don't have to create a new password reset disk.

Note that the disk you create can only be used with the computer on which it was created.

Shut Up, Shut Down!

Q When I try to shut down my computer, some applications stop responding and I have to manually end the processes. This doesn't cause any data loss, but it is irritating. Is there a way to automate termination of non-responding processes?

Shripad Gokhale



A Enabling the value AutoEndTasks in the Registry will take care of your issue. This is referred to as "Force Exit." In the Registry Editor, navigate to HKEY_USERS\DEFAULT\Control Panel\Desktop. Modify or create the String Value AutoEndTasks and give it a value of 1. If you only want this setting to apply to the currently logged-on user, go to HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Control Panel\Desktop.

Enforcing Change

Q I run a computer class and need the XP computers, which are password-protected, to force users to reset their passwords every month. These computers are not on a domain.

Anirudh Sharma

Illustrations Harsho Mohan Chatteraj

Get Help Now!

E-mail us your computing problems along with your contact details and complete system configuration to sos@jasubhai.com, and we might answer them here! Since we get many more mails per day than we can handle, it may take some time for your query to be answered. Rest assured, we are listening!